Among the three democratic BRICS, India is the most populous, has the greatest military capabilities, and since the mid-1990s, has grown the fastest. India plays an implicit bridging role within the BRICS club, being both Eastern—by virtue of geography and linguistic, religious, and ethnic identities—and Western, as reflected in its use of English as the primary language of national government and business and its largely British-born political and bureaucratic institutions, including a vibrant and contentious free press.[185] India played a particularly prominent role in the creation of new multilateral financial institutions controlled by the BRICS. Indian Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, an economist and former finance minister, exercised leadership in early discussions of the NDB and Contingent Reserve Arrangement (CRA), building on a long tradition of Indian international development advocacy extending back to the country's first postindependence leader, Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru (1947–1964). This section summarizes India's overall foreign policy orientations, its incentives to join in collective financial statecraft, and the country's complex relations with China.

India's Desire for Foreign Policy Autonomy

BRICS participation represents a logical extension of India's traditional diplomacy, which invokes idealism while simultaneously forging cross-cutting ties to maximize policymakers' freedom of action.[186] Since independence in 1947, India has committed to an independent foreign policy, viewing itself as a natural global player and champion of developing countries. Nehru's foreign policy vision promoted norms of multipolarity and nonalignment, even in an era in which the global balance of capabilities clearly was bipolar.

Nehru's daughter and political heir, Prime Minister Indira Gandhi (who served from 1964–1978 and 1980–1984), continued this tradition, proudly maintaining ties with both the United States and the Soviet Union. While Nehru promoted international independence as an abstract ideal, under Mrs. Gandhi, India's foreign policy more closely resembled traditional realist power balancing. In the early 1970s, she deepened defense ties with the Soviet Union and intervened in neighboring Pakistan's civil war in defense